AI PRODUCT MANAGEMENT 2 · DETAILED COURSE

Product Strategy and Roadmapping

Turning vision and research into focused strategy, an outcome-based roadmap, and defensible prioritisation and investment decisions.

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CHAPTER 03

Product Strategy and Roadmapping

Turning vision and research into focused strategy, an outcome-based roadmap, and defensible prioritisation and investment decisions.

Product Vision and Strategic Alignment

Connecting the product vision to company strategy so teams share direction and priorities.

Strategic alignment connects the product vision to company goals so teams share priorities. Without alignment, two teams can build excellent features that pull the company in opposite directions. Review the link between vision and goals every quarter.

Strategic Product Planning

Setting goals, bets and sequencing over quarters and years, balancing growth, quality and capacity.

Planning sets bets and sequencing across quarters and years, balancing growth, quality and team capacity. A plan should name the outcome each bet should move and what evidence would make you stop it.

Product Positioning

The place your product holds in the customer's mind relative to alternatives: for whom, what category and why better.

Positioning defines for whom the product is, which category it belongs to, and why it is better than the alternatives. A clear positioning statement lets sales, marketing and product describe the same thing.

Product Differentiation

The distinct, valued advantage that competitors cannot easily copy, such as data, workflow depth, brand or distribution.

Differentiation is a valued advantage competitors cannot easily copy, such as proprietary data, deep workflow integration or a trusted brand. A feature anyone can copy is parity, not differentiation.

Product Strategy Frameworks

Tools such as Playing to Win, Good Strategy (diagnosis, guiding policy, actions), Wardley maps and the three horizons model.

Frameworks such as Playing to Win ask where to play and how to win. Good Strategy separates diagnosis, guiding policy and coherent actions. Wardley maps show how components evolve over time. Use one framework consistently rather than many at once.

Product Roadmap Development

A communication tool showing problems and outcomes planned over time, flexible on detail and honest about uncertainty.

A roadmap communicates intent over time. Show problems and outcomes rather than dated promises for features. Mark what is committed, planned and exploratory, so stakeholders understand the uncertainty.

Outcome-Based Roadmapping

Organising the roadmap around customer and business outcomes instead of a feature list with dates.

An outcome roadmap groups work under the customer or business outcome it should change, such as reducing onboarding time by 30%. Teams then compete on ideas for that outcome rather than delivering a fixed list of features.

OKRs and KPIs

OKRs set ambitious objectives with measurable key results for a period; KPIs track ongoing health of the business or product.

OKRs set ambitious objectives with measurable key results for a period. KPIs track ongoing health, such as uptime or monthly active users. Use OKRs for change you are pursuing and KPIs for the health you must maintain.

North Star Metric

The single metric that best captures the value customers get, and that leads revenue.

The north star is the single measure that best captures the value customers receive, such as weekly songs played per listener. It leads revenue and guides the team. Support it with input metrics the team can directly influence.

Product Portfolio Management

Allocating investment across multiple products or bets by stage, risk and return.

Portfolio management allocates investment across products or bets by stage, risk and expected return. A healthy portfolio mixes proven products that fund growth with a few experiments that could become the next major line.

Feature Prioritisation

Ordering work by value, effort, risk and strategic fit with explicit criteria rather than opinion.

Prioritisation orders work by value, effort, risk and strategic fit using explicit criteria. Write the criteria down so the ranking can be challenged on the inputs rather than on personal opinion.

RICE Framework

Score = (Reach x Impact x Confidence) / Effort, a simple way to compare initiatives.

RICE scores an initiative as (Reach x Impact x Confidence) divided by Effort. Example: reaching 5,000 users with impact 2, confidence 80% and effort 2 person-months gives (5,000 × 2 × 0.8) / 2 = 4,000. Use the score to compare items, not to decide alone.

MoSCoW Framework

Classify requirements as Must, Should, Could and Won't have in this release to fix scope.

MoSCoW sorts requirements into Must, Should, Could and Won't-have for this release. It fixes scope early. Teams often label too many items as Must, so ask what fails if the item is removed.

Kano Model

Separates basic expectations, performance features and delighters to see how features affect satisfaction.

The Kano model separates basic expectations, performance features that scale satisfaction, and delighters that create surprise. Basic expectations must work or users leave. Delighters should be added after the basics are reliable.

ICE Scoring

Impact, Confidence and Ease scored 1-10 and multiplied or averaged for fast ranking.

ICE scores Impact, Confidence and Ease from 1 to 10 and combines them. It is quick for early ideas. Its weakness is subjectivity, so calibrate scores by comparing two or three items the whole team already understands.

Impact vs Effort Matrix

A 2×2 that shows quick wins, big bets, fill-ins and time sinks.

A two-by-two grid places items as quick wins (high impact, low effort), big bets, fill-ins and time sinks. It makes trade-offs visible in a single meeting. Plot items as a group discussion, not as one person's view.

Opportunity Scoring

Rates how important a customer need is against how satisfied they are; high importance with low satisfaction signals opportunity.

Opportunity scoring rates how important each customer need is and how satisfied customers are with current solutions. Needs that are important but poorly served point to opportunities. It works best with a survey of many customers.

Stakeholder Prioritisation

Aligning priorities with executives, sales, support and engineering using shared criteria and transparent trade-offs.

Stakeholders bring competing requests from sales, support and executives. Agree the criteria first, then score requests together. Show how each request ranks, so people see the trade-off rather than a decision made in private.

Strategic Trade-Offs

Choosing what not to do: speed vs quality, breadth vs depth, build now vs later, and documenting the reasoning.

Strategy requires saying no. Trade-offs include speed against quality, breadth against depth and building now against later. Record the reasoning and the conditions under which the decision would change.

Product Investment Decisions

Deciding where to put people and money using expected value, strategic fit, evidence and option value.

Investment decisions weigh expected value, strategic fit, evidence and option value, which is the value of keeping choices open. Stage investment so a bet earns more funding only after it hits defined evidence milestones.

Summary of terms

Term	Meaning
Product Vision and Strategic Alignment	Connecting the product vision to company strategy so teams share direction and priorities.
Strategic Product Planning	Setting goals, bets and sequencing over quarters and years, balancing growth, quality and capacity.
Product Positioning	The place your product holds in the customer's mind relative to alternatives: for whom, what category and why better.
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Product Strategy Frameworks	Tools such as Playing to Win, Good Strategy (diagnosis, guiding policy, actions), Wardley maps and the three horizons model.
Product Roadmap Development	A communication tool showing problems and outcomes planned over time, flexible on detail and honest about uncertainty.
Outcome-Based Roadmapping	Organising the roadmap around customer and business outcomes instead of a feature list with dates.
OKRs and KPIs	OKRs set ambitious objectives with measurable key results for a period; KPIs track ongoing health of the business or product.
North Star Metric	The single metric that best captures the value customers get, and that leads revenue.

Product Portfolio Management	Allocating investment across multiple products or bets by stage, risk and return.
Feature Prioritisation	Ordering work by value, effort, risk and strategic fit with explicit criteria rather than opinion.
RICE Framework	Score = (Reach x Impact x Confidence) / Effort, a simple way to compare initiatives.
MoSCoW Framework	Classify requirements as Must, Should, Could and Won't have in this release to fix scope.
Kano Model	Separates basic expectations, performance features and delighters to see how features affect satisfaction.
ICE Scoring	Impact, Confidence and Ease scored 1-10 and multiplied or averaged for fast ranking.
Impact vs Effort Matrix	A 2×2 that shows quick wins, big bets, fill-ins and time sinks.
Opportunity Scoring	Rates how important a customer need is against how satisfied they are; high importance with low satisfaction signals opportunity.
Stakeholder Prioritisation	Aligning priorities with executives, sales, support and engineering using shared criteria and transparent trade-offs.
Strategic Trade-Offs	Choosing what not to do: speed vs quality, breadth vs depth, build now vs later, and documenting the reasoning.
Product Investment Decisions	Deciding where to put people and money using expected value, strategic fit, evidence and option value.

Practice exercise: Score ten backlog ideas with RICE and again with ICE. Explain every place the rankings differ.

Self-check

1. Explain Product Vision and Strategic Alignment in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
2. Explain Feature Prioritisation in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
3. Explain Product Investment Decisions in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.

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